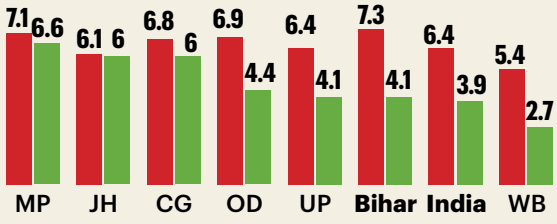
BIHAR'S ECONOMIC WOES

A SKEWED GROWTH

Among 'laggard' states, Bihar has shown most growth. But the farm sector has not kept pace

GSDP Growth **Agriculture GSDP Growth**
(Average annual growth rate in %; 2005–06 to 2024–25)

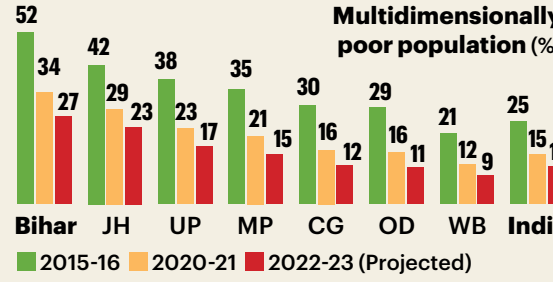


TRAPPED IN POVERTY



Despite gains, Bihar still has the highest poverty rates, reflecting stalled structural reforms

Multidimensionally poor population (%)

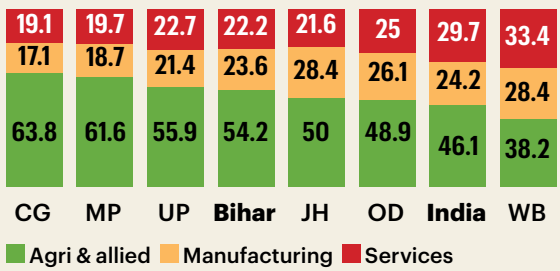


DEARTH OF JOBS

Farming employs a majority and non-farm jobs are barely expanding. So, millions outmigrate for work



Workforce distribution by sector (2023-24, %)

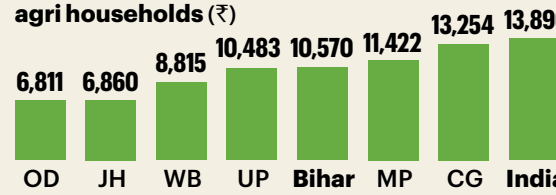


A PERSISTENT INCOME GAP



Despite employing so many, Bihar's farm sector delivers incomes far lower than the national average

Average monthly income of agri households (₹)



MP: Madhya Pradesh; CG: Chhattisgarh; JH: Jharkhand; UP: Uttar Pradesh; OD: Odisha; WB: West Bengal

Source: ICRIER, using MoSPI, NITI Aayog data

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

of not formally naming him as CM candidate, and also because, with 85 out of 101 seats, the JD(U) did nearly as well as the BJP's 89 out of 101 seats. But being the single-largest party in the House, the BJP's numerical heft is bound to make it more assertive in government, subtly altering the balance of power in the coalition. So the surface resemblance ends at the surface.

"The newly constituted Bihar assembly," says sociologist Professor Gyanendra Yadav of Patliputra University, "is markedly different from the previous House, for it eliminates any possibility of government formation without the BJP at its core. This fundamentally reduces the subtle leverage Nitish once enjoyed. While the BJP will, of course, support him, this tenure will likely see the party assert its own agenda, expand its footprint to a scale it has never achieved in Bihar, and attempt to encroach upon segments of the political space traditionally occupied by the RJD." This is evident in the induction of Ram Kirpal Yadav, who defeated Lalu Prasad's daughter, Misa Bharti, in the 2014 and 2019 Lok Sabha elections, before losing the seat to her in 2024. His inclusion is an invitation to the Yadavs to move beyond the RJD.

This mandate eliminates the possibility of any govt without BJP at its core. The party therefore is likely to assert its own agenda, expand its footprint and encroach on RJD's space

But that may be getting ahead of the script. In the immediate future, the new government will have to come good on the manifesto that fetched it a stupendous victory. One that was dense with guarantees, initiatives that reached deep into rural households and spoke directly to Bihar's most aspirational voters: women, young jobseekers and first-time participants in the state's developmental journey. On November 14, the day the results were an-